Hexaguard Bootcamp (Apple Group)

Task 2: Password Policy & Account Lockout Configuration

Windows Local Security Policy (secpol.msc) | 5 November 2026

1. Defined Policy

Our group defined a password policy and an account lockout policy to protect user accounts against guessing, brute-force and password-spraying attacks. The values below were configured in the Local Security Policy console.

Policy Setting	Chosen Value	Cybersecurity Importance
Minimum password length	12 characters	Makes passwords harder to guess or crack through brute-force attacks.
Password complexity	Enabled	Requires a mix of uppercase letters, lowercase letters, numbers and special characters, and rejects passwords containing the account name.
Account lockout threshold	3 invalid logon attempts	Helps prevent automated password-guessing and password-spraying attacks.
Account lockout duration	2 minutes	Temporarily blocks access after repeated failed attempts, discouraging attackers while letting legitimate users regain access automatically.
Reset account lockout counter after	2 minutes	Failed attempts are forgotten after 2 quiet minutes, so occasional typing mistakes do not add up to a lockout.
Allow Administrator account lockout	Enabled	Stops attackers from guessing the built-in Administrator password without limit.

How the lockout works: if a user enters a wrong password 3 times within 2 minutes, Windows locks the account for 2 minutes and then unlocks it automatically. A user who makes fewer than 3 mistakes and then waits 2 minutes starts again with a fresh count.

2. Configuration Evidence

Path: `Win + R` > `secpol.msc` > Security Settings > Account Policies.

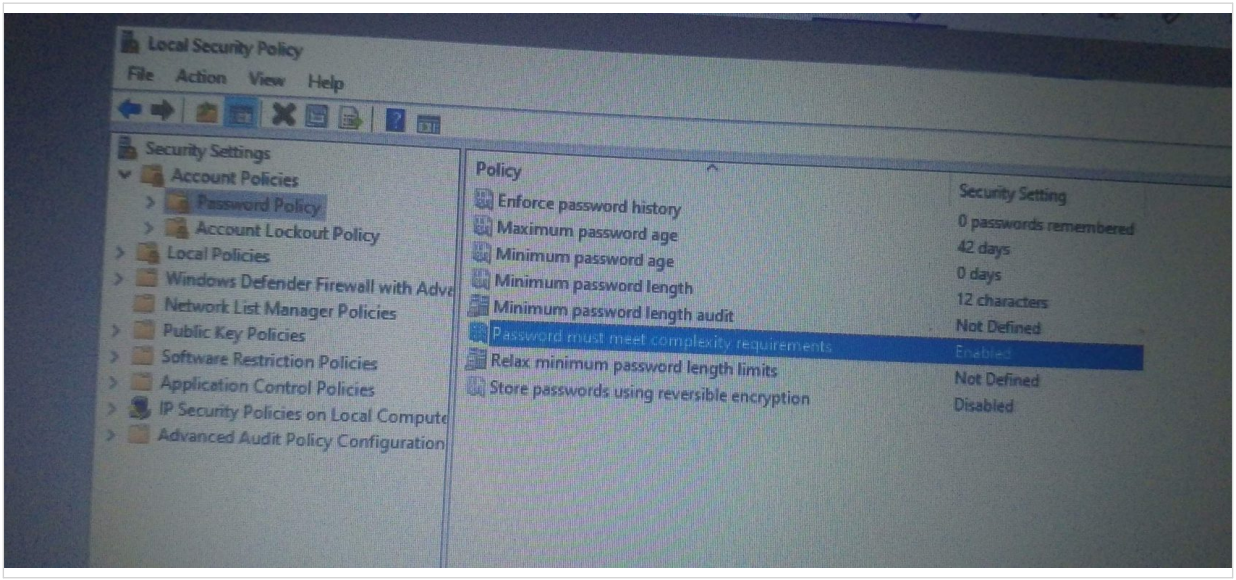


Figure 1: Password Policy. Minimum password length is 12 characters and password complexity requirements are Enabled.

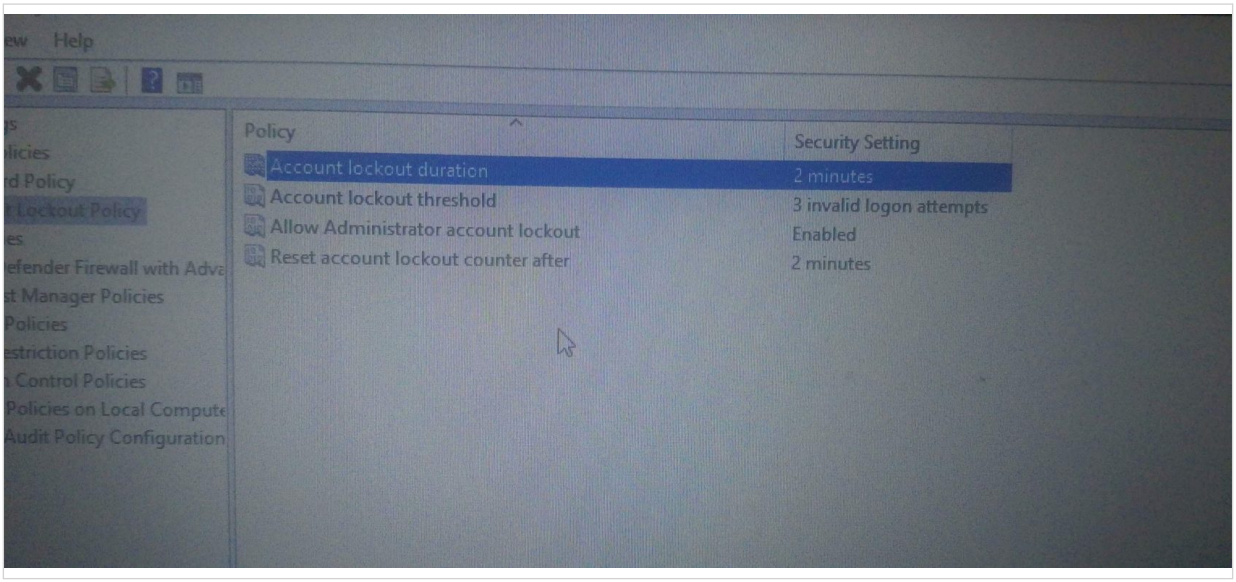


Figure 2: Account Lockout Policy. Threshold 3 invalid logon attempts, duration 2 minutes, reset counter after 2 minutes, Administrator account lockout Enabled.

3. Testing: The Policy Takes Effect

3.1 Policy is active on the system

Command run in Command Prompt:

```
net accounts
```

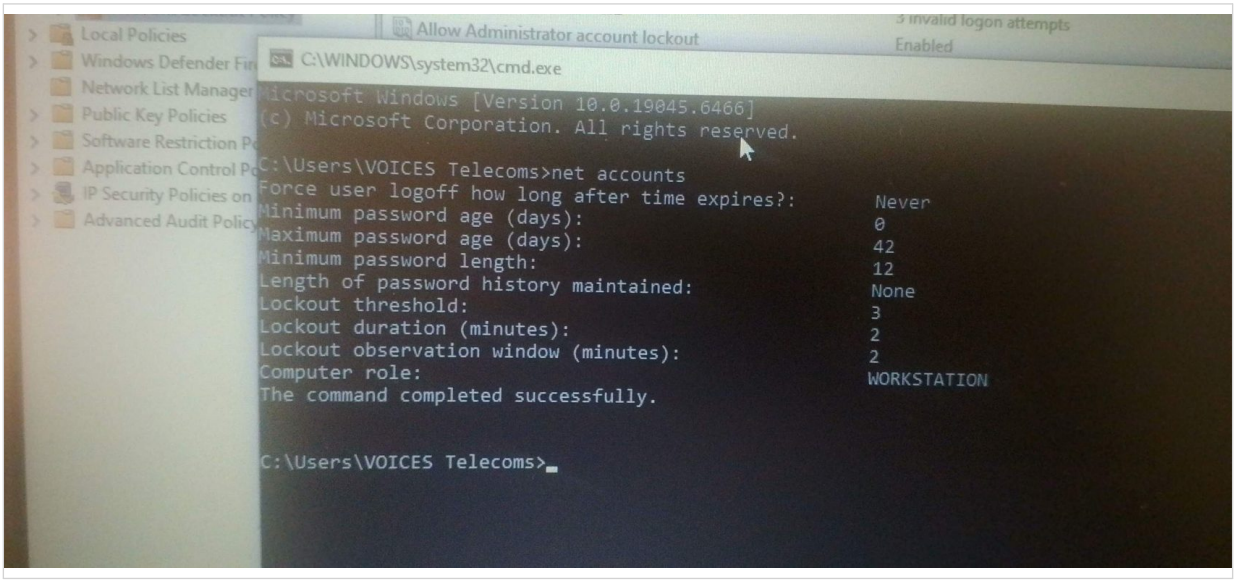


Figure 3: The output shows Minimum password length 12, Lockout threshold 3, Lockout duration 2 minutes and Lockout observation window 2 minutes. (The other lines are Windows defaults, not part of our policy.)

3.2 Weak password is rejected

A test account was created in PowerShell (Administrator) with a short password:

```
net user Hexaguard abc /add
```

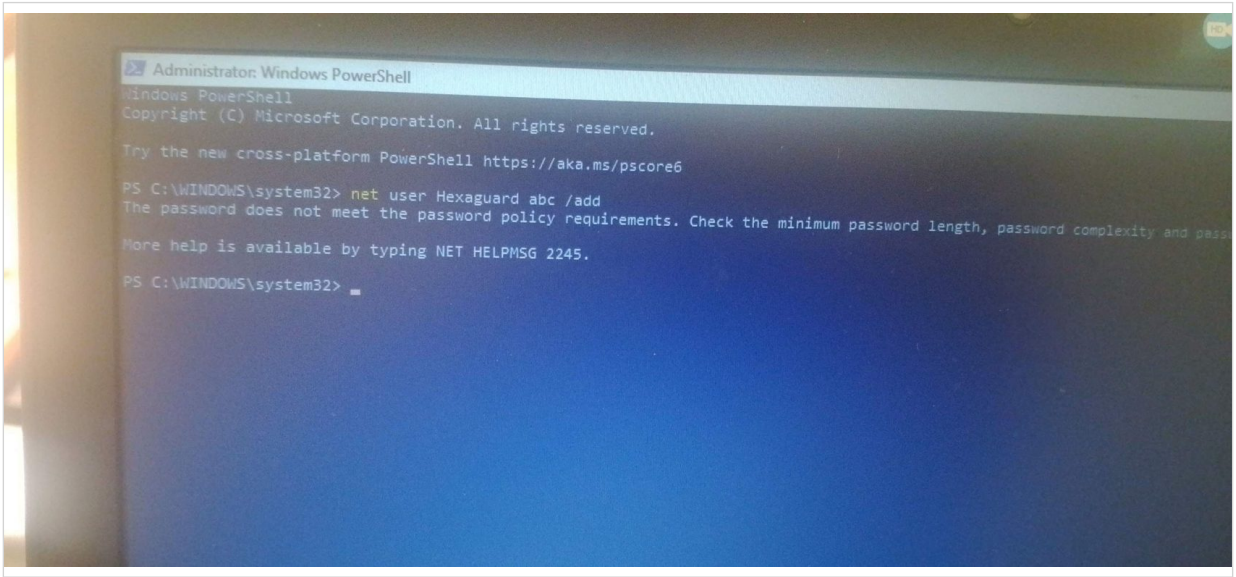


Figure 4: Windows refuses the account: "The password does not meet the password policy requirements." The minimum length rule is working.

3.3 Complexity rule rejects a password containing the username

A longer password that still contained the account name was tried. Windows first showed a warning about passwords over 14 characters (the answer Y was entered), then rejected it because it failed the complexity rule.

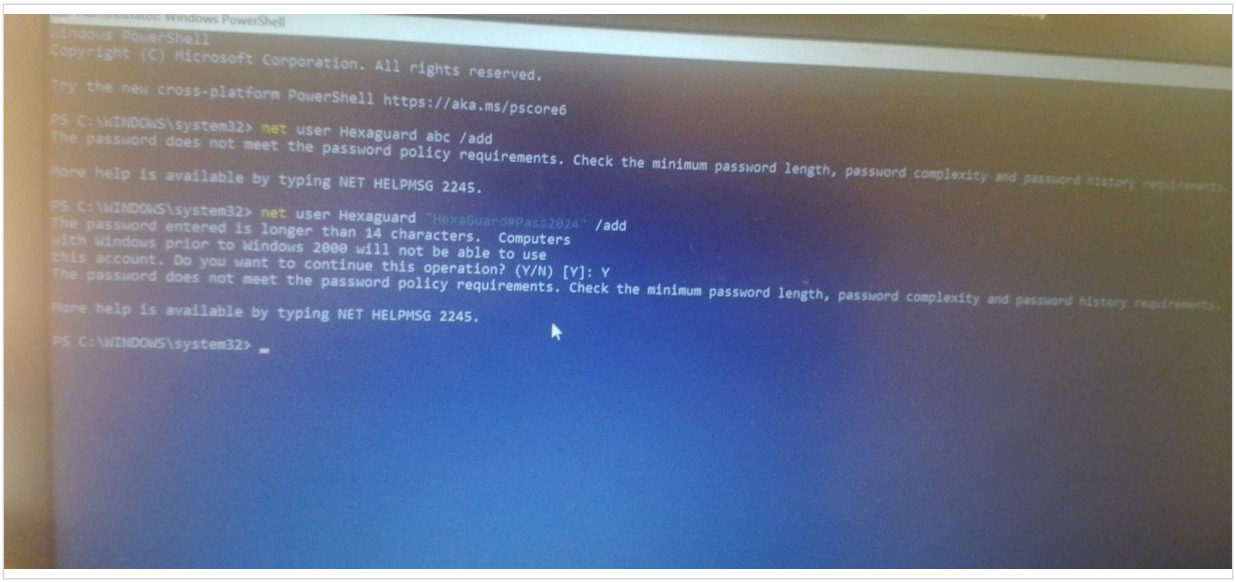


Figure 5: Even a long password is rejected when it contains the username, showing that password complexity is enforced.

3.4 Strong password is accepted

A password with uppercase, lowercase, a number and a symbol, not containing the username:

```
net user Hexaguard "<compliant password>" /add
```

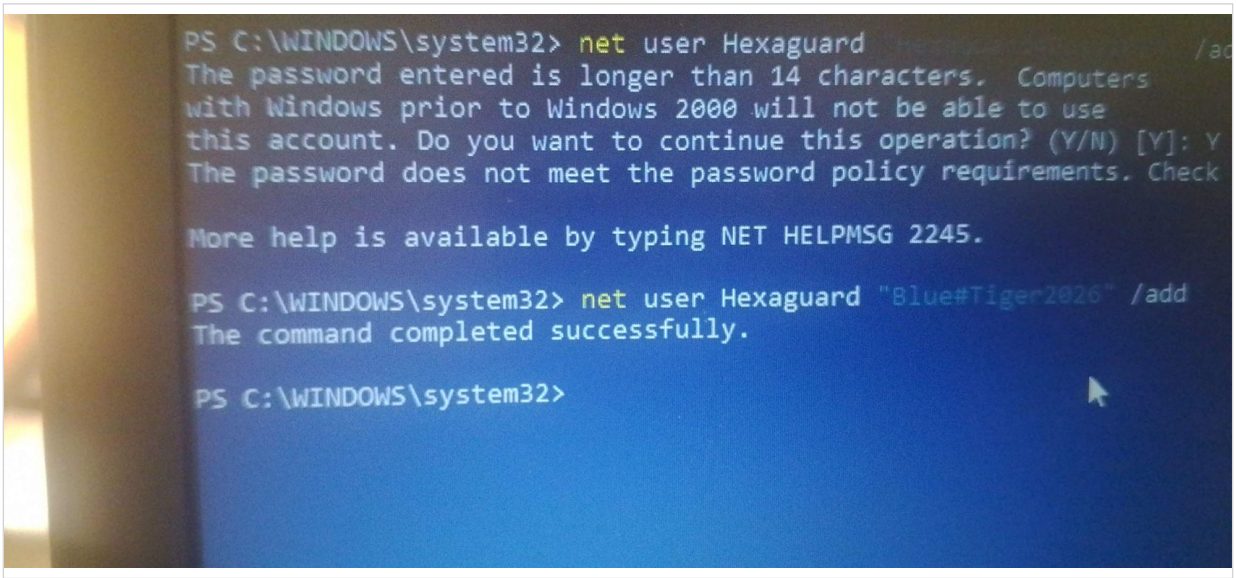


Figure 6: "The command completed successfully." The compliant password is accepted and the test user is created.

3.5 Account lockout after 3 wrong passwords

Wrong passwords were entered for the test user using the runas command:

```
runas /user:Hexaguard cmd
```

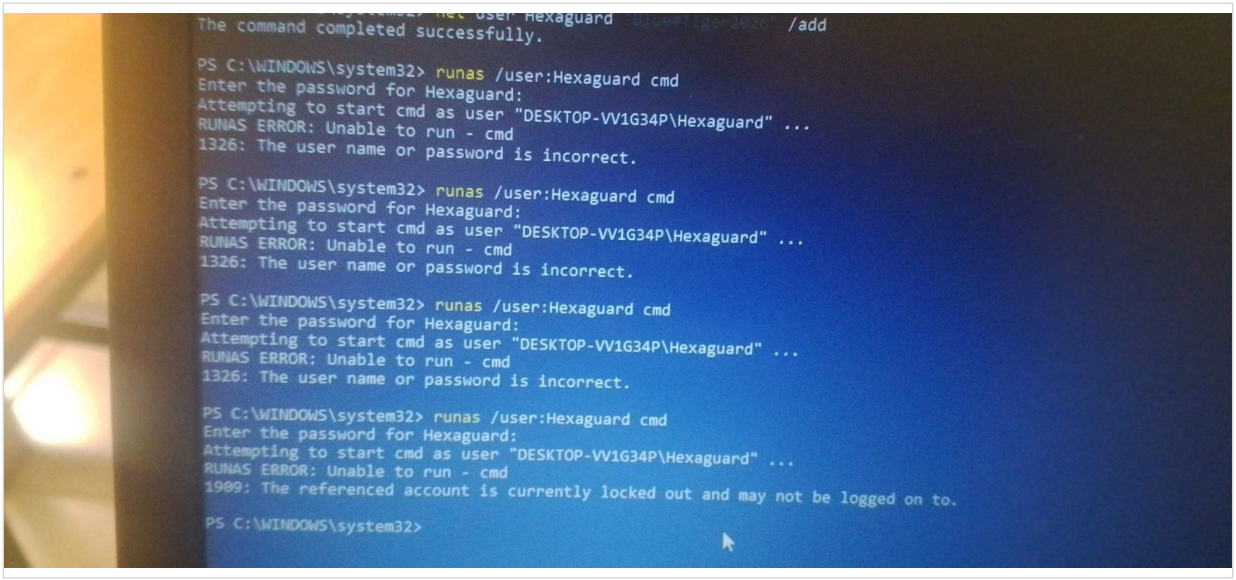


Figure 7: Attempts 1 to 3 fail with error 1326 (wrong password). The next attempt is blocked with error 1909: "The referenced account is currently locked out and may not be logged on to."

The same lockout was also tested from the real Windows sign-in screen: the computer was locked with `Win + L` and three incorrect passwords were entered for the Hexaguard account.

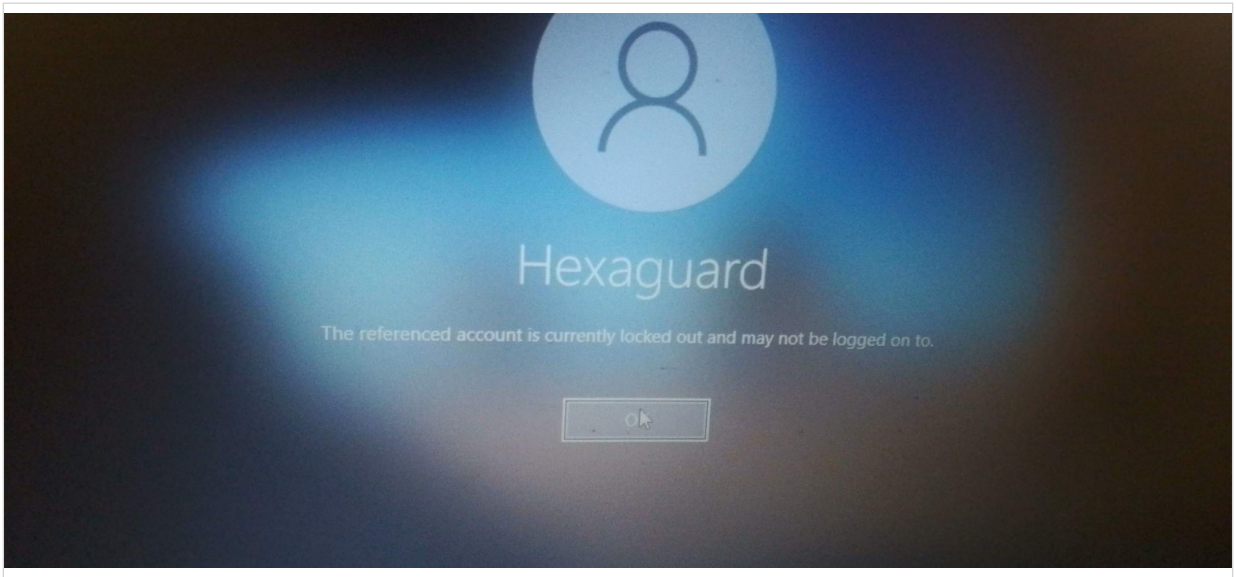


Figure 8: Windows sign-in screen for Hexaguard: "The referenced account is currently locked out and may not be logged on to."

3.6 Locked status, then automatic unlock

`net user Hexaguard` was run straight after the lockout, and again once the 2-minute duration had passed.

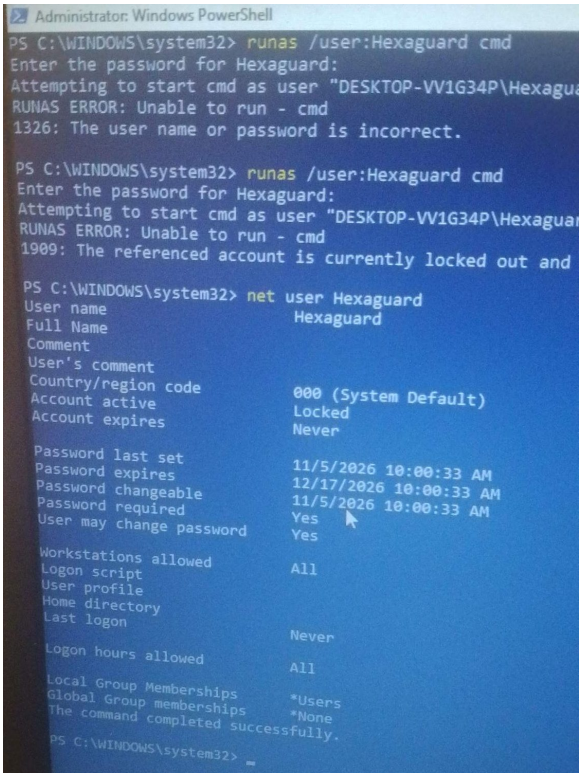


*Figure 9: Right after the failed attempts the status reads **Account active: Locked**.*

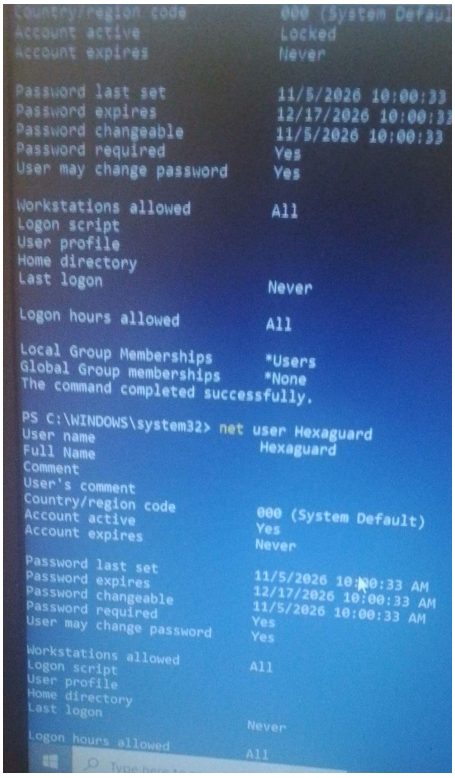


*Figure 10: The top still shows the earlier **Locked** result. The newer result below it shows **Account active: Yes**, so the account unlocked itself after 2 minutes.*

4. Results Summary

Test	Expected	Result
net accounts shows the policy	Length 12, threshold 3, duration 2, window 2	Passed (Fig. 3)
Weak password (abc)	Rejected	Passed (Fig. 4)
Password containing username	Rejected by complexity	Passed (Fig. 5)
Compliant strong password	Accepted	Passed (Fig. 6)
3 wrong logons	Account locked	Passed (Fig. 7 to 9)
Wait 2 minutes	Account unlocks automatically	Passed (Fig. 10)

5. Conclusion

The password and account lockout policy was defined, configured in Local Security Policy and verified. Weak and non-compliant passwords were rejected, a compliant password was accepted, three wrong logons locked the test account, and the account unlocked on its own after the 2-minute duration. Together, these controls make guessing and brute-force attacks against local accounts much harder.

Cleanup: the test user was removed afterwards with `net user Hexaguard /delete`.